PSCI 3328 - International Relations

Lecture 3 - Anarchy and Hierarchy

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PSCI 3328 - Attendance

Introduction

- You can start organizing/contacting your teammates (be wary of deadlines)
- Remember to contribute to eLearning forum
- Today: on Anarchy and Hierarchy

Today's Schedule

- Anarchy: an introduction
- Traditional vs. alternative views
- Contextualizing Hierarchy (sneak peek for next lecture)

Anarchy: an introduction

What did you get out of the readings? Are the main points of the 3 readings different?

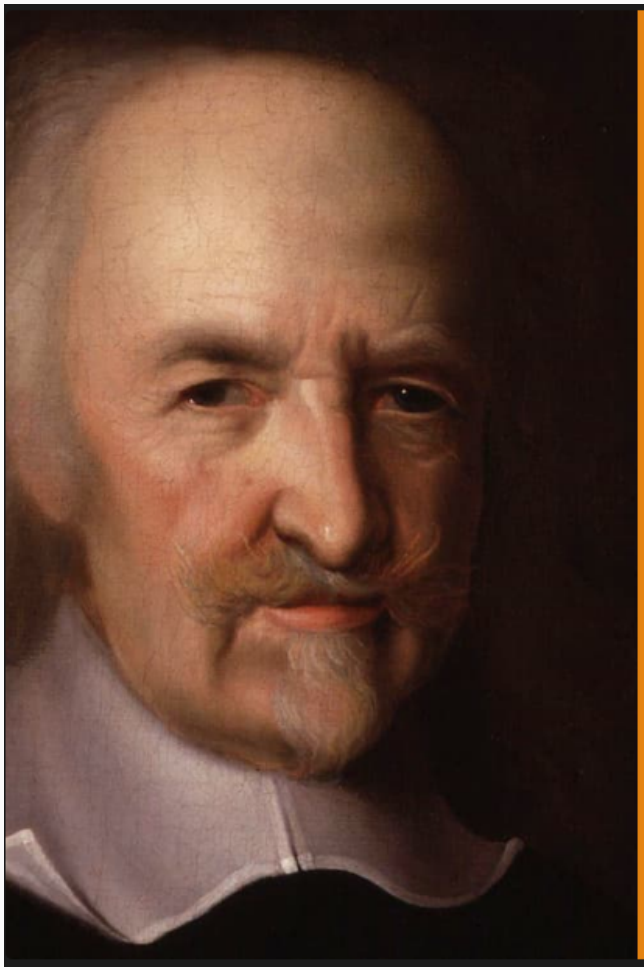
3 Questions

1. What is anarchy?
2. What are the effects of anarchy? (Traditionally vs. more recently)
3. How do we solve the issues of anarchy?

Let’s Start with You

What does “anarchy” mean to you?

According to Thomas Hobbes



"In the nature of man, we find three principal causes of quarrel: First, competition; secondly, diffidence (fear), thirdly, glory. The first maketh man invade for gain; the second, for safety; and the third, for reputation."

Two Very Different Meanings

Colloquial: Chaos, disorder, Mad Max

IR Theory: Absence of overarching authority

Critical distinction: Anarchy ≠ chaos

- Order can exist without central government
- International system is anarchic but has patterns

The Core Logic

If there's no authority above states:

- States must rely on **themselves** for security (self-help)
- Can't trust others to protect you
- Must worry about **relative power** (not just absolute)

Hobbes: Without government, life is "nasty, brutish, and short"

Same logic applied to states

The Security Dilemma

Consider two peaceful states:

- State A builds military (defensive intent)
- State B sees this as threatening
- State B builds up in response
- State A sees B's actions as confirming threat
- **Spiral continues** even though neither wanted conflict

The trap: Your security = their insecurity

Can this be prevented?

The Melian Dialogue

Athens to Melos: “The strong do what they can and the weak suffer what they must” (Thucydides)

Munich Agreement 1938: Czechoslovakia forced to give up territory, not even invited to negotiations

Pattern: In anarchy, power matters more than right (especially relative power)

Cooperation?

What about cooperation then?

Traditional vs. alternative views

Traditional Effects of Anarchy

Anarchy produces predictable patterns:

1. **Self-help**: Can only rely on yourself
2. **Balancing**: Prevent any one power from dominating
3. **Relative gains matter**: Your position vs. rivals
4. **Like units**: All states face similar pressures

Key claim: Structure shapes and constrains state behavior

International politics as constant security competition

Structure Matters

The structural argument:

- International **structure** = ordering principle (anarchy) + distribution of capabilities
- Structure determines what states **can** and **must** do
- States are "like units" - functionally undifferentiated
  - All must provide own security
  - All must conduct foreign policy

Implication: Democracies and dictatorships face same structural pressures

Balancing Behavior

The logic: - If one state gets too powerful → threatens everyone

- Others form coalitions to counterbalance
- Can be internal (build up own power) or external (alliances)
- Prevents hegemony

Examples: Coalitions against Napoleon, Allied vs. Axis powers, NATO vs. Warsaw Pact

Structural claim: This happens regardless of leaders' intentions or domestic politics

Relative vs. Absolute Gains

Two deals:

Deal A: You gain $100, rival gains $50

Deal B: You gain $75, rival gains $75

Which one do you prefer?

Why Relative Gains?

Positional competition: Your rank matters for survival

- Security is **positional** (not absolute)
- Today's partner could be tomorrow's threat
- Can't ignore how cooperation affects power balance
- Makes cooperation difficult even when mutually beneficial

Does this logic make sense? When might it break down?

But Is This Inevitable?

Traditional view: These effects flow from structure itself

Alternative question: Does anarchy **determine** these outcomes?

Do material structures determine behavior? Or do ideas and identities matter?

But... A Puzzle

If anarchy inevitably produces conflict...

How do we explain anarchic systems that are peaceful?

Forager Societies

Hunter-gatherer societies:

- Truly anarchic (no government)
- Independent bands
- Yet **“warless societies”** (minimal violent conflict)

Why are they different?

What matters? Some pointers from Donnelly

1. Stratification - degree to which units are *hierarchically arranged*
2. Functional Differentiation - the degree to which units assume specialized roles
3. Unit differentiation - differences of units within the system
4. Norms and institutions - rules and expectations
5. Geotechnics - geography and technology
6. Polarity - number of great powers and power concentration

Anarchy is one element among many

Consider:

- UN, WTO, ICC exist (institutions)
- International law followed most of the time
- Some force is considered legitimate internationally
- Great powers ≠ small states (not equal units)

Maybe it's not pure anarchy?

The Social Construction Challenge

Key question: Are these effects of anarchy **given by structure**?

Or are they **created through interaction**?

Consider:

- US-UK relations: cooperation despite anarchy
- US-Soviet Cold War: intense rivalry
- US-Canada: "security community"

<u>What explains these different outcomes if structure is the same?</u>

Identities Shape Interests

Traditional view: States have fixed interests (survival, power)

Alternative view: Interests depend on **identities**

- If others are **enemies** → interest in domination/defense
- If others are **rivals** → interest in independence/competition
- If others are **friends** → interest in cooperation/mutual gain

Where do these identities come from?

Contextualizing Hierarchy (sneak peek for next lecture)

Beyond Pure Anarchy

Is the international system really purely anarchic?

Look around: - NATO (clear leader) - European Union (supranational authority) - US military bases in 80+ countries - Historical empires and colonies

What Is Hierarchy?

Hierarchy: Authority relationships where some actors have right to command and others have duty to obey

Where does authority come from in international politics?

Authority vs. Coercion

Coercion: Compliance based on threat of force - “Do this or I’ll hurt you” - Unstable, requires constant enforcement - Purely material power

Authority: Compliance based on legitimacy - “Do this because I have the right to ask” - Stable, taken for granted - Social recognition matters

What makes authority legitimate?

Voluntary Hierarchy

Critical insight: States often **choose** to accept hierarchy

Why?

- Benefits of cooperation exceed costs of lost autonomy
- Security guarantees
- Economic advantages
- Access to collective problem-solving

Authority relationships involve consent, not just coercion

Forms of Hierarchy

Throughout history and today:

1. **Empires**: Direct rule over territories
2. **Protectorates**: Control foreign policy, not domestic
3. **Alliances**: Unequal partners with clear leaders
4. **Economic dependencies**: Structural subordination
5. **Informal influence**: Through aid, institutions, norms

What are some examples today?

Hierarchy and Polarity

Traditional view: International structure = anarchy + polarity (distribution of power)

Alternative view: Structure varies in **both** anarchy/hierarchy **and** polarity

- Some relationships more hierarchical than others
- Different types of hierarchy serve different functions
- Can't just assume anarchy

Why Does This Matter?

If hierarchy is pervasive:

- Need to explain **when** states accept it vs. resist
- Need to understand **what forms** it takes
- Need to analyze **how** it interacts with anarchy
- Can hierarchy solve problems anarchy can't?

Different theoretical implications than pure anarchy

The Theoretical Debate

Structural realism: Anarchy is THE ordering principle, variation only in polarity

Alternative views: - Hierarchy coexists with anarchy - Authority relationships shape who decides what - Need to study variation in hierarchy, not assume pure anarchy - Norms and systems outside of anarchy

A final question

If we agree with the term and what it means for IR, how do we “solve anarchy”?

Summary

- Anarchy as absence of authority
- Traditional view: anarchy produces self-help, balancing, relative gains, like units
- Alternative view: effects of anarchy depend on social context, identities, institutions
- Hierarchy as something that modifies structure and relationship

Looking Ahead to Wednesday

Next class: How do states navigate anarchy and hierarchy in practice?

Group Work: Map of seating areas on eLearning (with final project team members for Wednesday, other days I will create ad-hoc teams and assign temporary numbers. Seating areas will be the same.)

Questions?